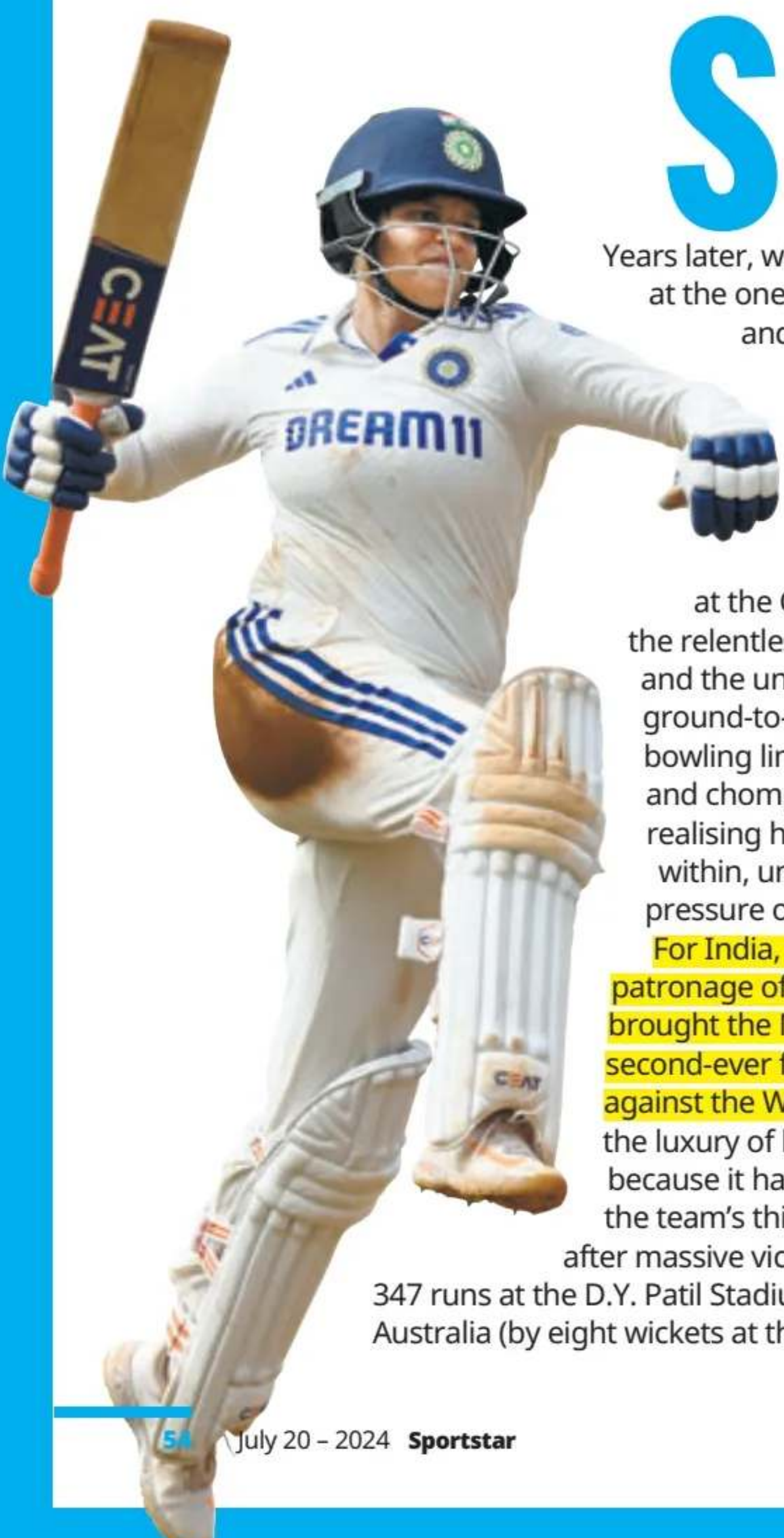


When Chepauk proved that resilience too needs support

South Africa's gritty defiance in the face of a humbling loss against India might have earned it respect and a place in history, but **will it change its red-ball destiny** back home?

Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan
lavanya.ln@thehindu.co.in



South African skipper Laura Wolvaardt often slips into a one-liner when she tries to explain a game's complexities: "Cricket's a funny game." It truly is. Years later, when people will look back at the one-off Test between India and South Africa at the MA Chidambaram Stadium in Chennai, they might see the big scores and historic wicket-hauls, but they won't feel what the 12,000-odd spectators at the Chepauk experienced — the relentless defence of the Proteas and the unending chirpiness of a ground-to-the-ground Indian bowling lineup. You'll see the bun and chomp down on it without even realising how those layers formed within, under the intense heat and pressure of the coastal city.

For India, whose newfound patronage of women's Tests has brought the MAC Stadium just its second-ever fixture since the one against the West Indies in 1976, there is the luxury of brushing past this win because it has become the norm. This is the team's third Test triumph on the trot after massive victories over England (by 347 runs at the D.Y. Patil Stadium in Navi Mumbai) and Australia (by eight wickets at the Wankhede Stadium in

Mumbai). The highs have facilitated the formation of a stable red-ball core and now a revitalised domestic tournament.

South Africa is a polar opposite. In the history of Tests for women, it has played only 15 to India's 41, of which three have just happened in the last two years after an eight-year red-ball hiatus. The Proteas have a solitary win in the format, which came against the Netherlands in 2007.

Wolvaardt's side has been the only one outside the 'Big Three' to show both interest and ability to invest in the game's longest format for its women. However, their efforts so far have remained confined to the international realm.

South Africa does not have any red-ball or multi-day cricket at the domestic level and came into the Chennai Test having last played the format in a thrashing at the hands of Australia — an innings and 284-run defeat — in Perth earlier this year.

Coming into this fixture, Wolvaardt had issued an ultimatum of sorts.

"We need to play more Test cricket and incorporate it into our domestic system and practice, or we must just leave it because playing one in three years is very hard to adapt to. But I am on the side to have more of it," she said.

With a weak spin arsenal on a traditionally spin-favouring surface,